by an expert body like the state's Tribal Research and Training Institute (TRTI), recommendations are sent to a sub-committee under the tribal development minister and the tribal advisory council (TAC). The state cabinet approves a recommendation and then forwards it to the Union government. The opinions of the registrar general and census commissioner of India and the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes are also sought.

Congress leader and former minister Padmakar Valvi thinks Dhangar leaders are trying to capitalise on a similarity in names between their caste and the Dhangad tribals. "Tribals are outside the mainstream. If a community as large as the Dhangars is added, their situation will worsen," says Valvi, who heads the Tribal Rights Protection Committee. Valvi explains that to be categorised as tribals, groups need to meet certain criteria. For instance, tribals stay away from mainstream settlements (both urban and rural), practise animism and worship unique deities like Waghdev (a tiger god), and even trees, soil and grain, often using liquor made from *mohua* flowers in rituals. And they speak their own distinct languages, like Bhili or Bhilori, Pawra and Kokni—the last being the tribe believed to have given its name to Konkan.

Valvi says the Dhangar community's demand flows from no other logic except their desire for greater access to state and central government jobs using the ST quota. "They (Dhangar leaders) also want to be elected from seats reserved for STs...after inclusion in the category, it will be easy to purchase prime land held by tribals abutting national highways and dams," he explains.

Suhas Naik, vice-president of the Nandurbar zilla parishad and tribal leader, says they will launch a campaign stressing how the BJP was "anti-tribal."

PUNJAB

# ALLIANCE HITS VIGILANCE BUMP

**By Anilesh S. Mahajan**

It was at the crack of dawn on September 28 that a Punjab police contingent landed at Congress MLA Sukhpal Singh Khaira's residence in Chandigarh. They were there to arrest him in a 2015 drugs bust case where his alleged aide, Gurdev Singh, and nine others were convicted. The police say Khaira's name emerged later in the investigation, in 2017, which is why he is calling it "political vendetta". In February this year, the Supreme Court did quash a summons in the case, but in 2021, the Enforcement Directorate had charged him with money-laundering. He had spent 80 days in jail before getting bail. This time, after two days of police custody, Khaira was sent to judicial custody.

In six years, a lot has changed for Khaira. Back in 2017, he was leader of the opposition in the assembly as an Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) legislator. Those days, he was blaming the 'vendetta' on the Congress regime of the time, but now, since his return to the party, Khaira's vitriol is reserved for his erstwhile colleagues in the ruling AAP. More than his own twisted fortunes, the police action has come as a thorny turn in the ties between the two parties at the national level—they are both part of the national opposition INDIA bloc. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge has already warned that if "they (AAP) do injustice with us, it won't be tolerated".

AAP is reportedly keen on an alliance for the 2024 general election, but the Congress's local units in Delhi and Punjab have vociferously opposed the tie-up. In Punjab, the biggest grouse against the Bhagwant Mann-led government is the "misuse" of the vigilance bureau. Mann doesn't leave any chance to run down Congress leaders, calling them out on charges such as corruption and hobnobbing with the drug mafia. Incidentally, a week before Khaira's arrest, the Congress had organised an anti-drugs rally in Faridkot to put pressure on AAP for not taking on the drugs mafia.

Vendetta politics or not, the AAP government has been after some of the big fish in the former Congress regime. Even as the INDIA talks were on, former deputy CM O.P. Soni and ex-MLA Kushaldeep Singh Dhillon were arrested on disproportionate assets charges. Soni is still behind bars. Ex-Punjab CM Charanjit Singh Channi has been grilled twice, and ex-ministers B.B. Ashu, Sadhu S. Dharamsot and Sundar S. Arora are also facing arrest in corruption cases, as is Punjab unit chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring. Former ministers Manpreet Badal,



ANI

**IN CUSTODY**
Congress leader Sukhpal Khaira waves to supporters as he leaves the Jalalabad court, September 28